

Mobile Watch**26**

The crown sitting tight on Nokia's head was seized by Samsung last year, Sony is on no.3 now and more smartphones-related news covered

App Watch**30**

A lot happened in the app-world last month and we round up the 10 apps from iOS and Android that you must try

Security alerts, IPv6 to fight cyber crime and more...

There was a lot that happened on the security front: DRDO launching an Indian OS; Airtel announcing emergency alert service, Symantec's new secure cloud storage

While no major hacks occurred in December, a lot of new security services were launched. Some stats such as the total number of Indian websites hacked from January to October 2012, were released.

India also took various steps to ensure that 2013 sees its security frontiers better protected, deploying IPv6 and starting development on a new independent OS.

Bharti Airtel introduces emergency alert service

Bharti Airtel has introduced a 24 X 7 emergency alert service for its customers. The service enables Airtel customers to send an alert with their geographic location to their 10 contacts in an emergency situation.

"During an emergency, Airtel mobile customers can now send an alert with their geographic location to their closest 10 loved ones simultaneously with just a call, facilitating an access to easy and quick help," Airtel says in a statement.

Airtel's Emergency Alert Service is available for Rs. 30 with a validity of 30 days. Users can send the alert even if they don't have minimum balance in their account. To send the alert via SMS, users need to type HELP in the message box and send it to 55100, which will be then sent to all 10 contacts. To send the alert via call, users

need to call at 55100 and the registered contacts will get the voice alerts with location details of the customer.

Airtel hopes its new emergency alert service will see adoption by customers from all segments including, working women, senior citizens, teenagers and migrant workers. Airtel says the service could be really helpful in staying connected with their friends and families in case of natural calamities or disasters such as fire and accidents. According to Airtel, the service will ensure a user can seek help round the clock.

Indigenous OS to ramp up cybersecurity

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) is working on an indigenous operating system in a bid to secure the country's cyber network. According to DRDO director-general V K Saraswat, the Indian OS will be ready in couple of years. Saraswat further revealed that about 150 engineers have been working on the OS for the last one and half years.

India mainly depends on imported OSes based on Windows and Linux, which may have security risks, he noted. "To secure our cyber network, our own OS for computers is highly essential," Saraswat said adding the cyber criminals were on the loose, and cyber and network security have become an area of concern.



"The system will ensure that we are independent of what's happening outside and ensure the safety of our own networks," he said. He also stressed the need for indigenous manufacturing of good hardware.

Indian government to deploy IPv6 to combat cybercrime

In a significant step towards fighting cybercrime, the Indian government has stepped up the process of allocation of the newest IP addresses, IPv6. But it's not just the allocation of the new addresses, but also the localisation of the process that's going to further add efficiency to the whole process.

Earlier, allocation of IPv6 was handled by an Australian internet-registrar, Asia Pacific Network Information Center, who did not share their database freely and in a timely fashion in the event of a cybercrime.

However, the government has set up Indian Registry for Internet Names & Numbers (IRINN), a division of the National Internet Exchange

of India (NIXI). "It will now be easier to detect cybercrime as the database of registered internet addresses can be monitored real-time by security agencies," said a top official in the department of electronics & information technology.

The localisation of IPv6 registry has also been subsidized heavily by the government, with an address block costing only ₹21,999 as against the earlier AU\$1180 (roughly ₹68,440). NIXI hopes that a much cheaper price point will help push the adoption of the new IP system much faster.

The current IP address system, IPv4 only allows roughly 4 billion addresses, a number that was exhausted on February 3, 2011. What this has done is that it has allowed the allocation of one address to multiple users, making it very difficult to track the source of an attack. The address book of the IPv6 runs well into trillions, so each device will eventually have a unique IP address, making it very easy to track the source down.

More than 14,000 Indian sites hacked: CERT-In

Cybercriminals have gone on a rampage. According to data revealed by Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), more than 14,000 websites were hacked from January to October 2012, a sharp increase of 57 percent from 2009.